CHAPTER 8 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The Election of 1864

In the middle of a civil war, the United States did something no nation at war had ever done: it stopped to hold an election. 1864.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

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Should a country hold a free election in the middle of a war it might lose — and let the voters decide whether to keep fighting?

Lincoln vs. McClellan

TWO MEN, TWO FUTURES

The choice was stark. Abraham Lincoln, running on the National Union ticket, stood for fighting the war through to total victory — and for ending slavery forever with a constitutional amendment.

His opponent was George B. McClellan — the general Lincoln had once fired. McClellan's Democratic party ran on a platform declaring the war a "failure" and calling for a negotiated peace with the Confederacy.

"Grand National Union Banner for 1864" — campaign print, Currier & Ives, public domain (Library of Congress).

Lincoln and Johnson

THE NATIONAL UNION TICKET

Lincoln chose Andrew Johnson, a Southern Unionist, as his running mate to signal a united country. Their banner promised "Liberty, Union, and Victory."

"Grand National Union Banner for 1864" —

"Grand National Union Banner for 1864" — Lincoln and Johnson campaign print, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Stakes

WHAT PEACE WOULD HAVE MEANT

A negotiated peace sounded humane to a war-weary public. But it carried a hidden price: to stop the war, the Union would almost certainly have had to recognize the Confederacy — and allow slavery to survive in it.

So the election was really a referendum on the war's deepest questions: Keep fighting, and end slavery? Or make peace, and let the nation stay split and partly enslaved?

“The True Issue, or ‘That’s What’s the Matter’” — campaign cartoon, Currier & Ives, 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

“The True Issue”

A CAMPAIGN CARTOON

In this Democratic cartoon, a tiny McClellan stands between Lincoln and Jefferson Davis, each tearing at a map of the Union, as if only McClellan could hold the country together. Campaign images made the argument in pictures.

“The True Issue, or ‘That's What's the Matter’” — campaign cartoon, 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Men Who Were Fighting Voted

THE SOLDIERS DECIDE

One group's vote carried enormous weight: the soldiers. They had every reason to want the war over — yet they voted overwhelmingly for Lincoln, roughly 3 to 1. They would not see their sacrifice end in a peace that left the job undone.

Boosted by the fall of Atlanta and the soldier vote, Lincoln won in a landslide — 212 electoral votes to 21. The nation had voted, in the middle of a war, to finish it.

Turning points, 1863–65 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

Judge the Arguments

YOUR TURN

You'll put the two 1864 platforms side by side and practice argumentation — weighing each side's claims and explaining why the voters, and the soldiers, chose as they did.